



The Lazy Developer

07

MODULE

External Integrations with Automation Workflows

Using a workflow automation tool like Make.com to build automatic workflows as a part of your app or for a specific purpose. We will build a workflow out for a beta sign up as an example.

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Section 1: What Workflow Tools Are Out There?

Building an app isn't just about what happens inside the app but it's also about connecting it to the outside world. Workflow automation tools let you link your app with other services and tools, so things can happen automatically in the background. For example, when someone signs up on your site, a workflow could send them an email or text message with a special offer available for a short term to get the user to convert to a customer very quickly.

Think of these workflows as a series of connected steps: something happens (like a form is submitted), and then one or more actions take place across the apps and platforms you use. These automations help keep your data organized, save you time, and open up new possibilities for how your app works with the rest of your tech stack.

We'll go into specific examples and the power of these automations in the next section. But first, let's get familiar with the main tools that make these workflows possible.

At the time of this writing, AI agents are starting to do some of this work themselves but they're still a bit more complex. We discuss them in a later module you can go read.

The Main Workflow Automation Tools

There are a handful of workflow automation platforms that have become industry standards. Each one has its own strengths, style, and sweet spot. Here are the three most popular options you'll see non-coders and developers alike using:

The Big Three Workflow Automation Platforms: Deeper Dive

1. Zapier

Overview:

Zapier is the most recognized name in workflow automation. It's built for simplicity and works with thousands of apps right out of the box.

Strengths:

- Extremely easy to use: Great for beginners, with a clean and friendly interface.
- Huge integration library: Over 5,000 apps supported, including almost all major SaaS products.
- Reliability: Known for uptime and consistent execution.
- Lots of templates: Quickly get started with pre-made "Zaps" for common use cases.
- Great documentation and help articles.

Weaknesses:

- Limited customization: Some advanced logic (like complex branching or looping) is only available on higher plans, or not possible at all.
- Pricing: Can get expensive as you scale up your automations and require more “tasks” per month.
- Data handling: Not as robust for complex data transformations or multi-step workflows.
- No on-premise/self-hosting option.

Pricing:

- Free tier: Up to 100 tasks/month, single-step Zaps only.
- Starter: ~\$20/month, up to 750 tasks/month, multi-step Zaps.
- Professional: ~\$50/month, up to 2,000 tasks/month, more features like paths (conditional logic).
- Team & Company: Higher tiers for teams, with advanced permissions and higher usage limits.
- Zapier Pricing

Support:

- Email support, fast responses on paid plans.
- Extensive help center, user community, and how-to guides.

Review Scores (2025):

- G2: 4.5/5 (based on thousands of reviews)
- Capterra: 4.7/5

2. Make

Overview:

Make offers more control and flexibility than Zapier, with a beautiful visual editor and powerful data handling tools. It’s a favorite for users who want to go beyond the basics.

Strengths:

- Visual workflow builder: Drag-and-drop interface for mapping out complex processes.
- Advanced logic: Filters, routers (branching), iterators, and more for handling real-world workflows.
- Great value: More features at a lower price point than many competitors.
- Detailed data manipulation: Map, filter, and transform data as it moves between apps.

Weaknesses:

- Learning curve: Can feel overwhelming for total beginners.

- App library is smaller than Zapier: Still covers most popular apps, but sometimes new integrations take longer to appear.
- Support can be slow: Especially on lower-priced or free plans.
- No self-hosting option.

Pricing (2025):

- Free tier: Up to 1,000 operations/month, limited features.
- Core: ~\$10/month, up to 10,000 operations/month.
- Pro: ~\$16/month, up to 10,000 operations/month, priority support.
- Teams & Enterprise: Higher limits and features for larger orgs.
- Make Pricing

Support:

- Email support (faster on Pro plans).
- Help docs, forum, and a growing knowledge base.

Review Scores (2025):

- G2: 4.8/5
- Capterra: 4.7/5

3. N8N

Overview:

N8N is an open-source workflow automation tool that gives you the option to host it yourself for maximum control, privacy, and customizability. It's ideal for technical users and teams who want flexibility.

Strengths:

- Open source: No vendor lock-in, modify the code if you want.
- Self-hosting: Run on your own servers or cloud (great for privacy, compliance, or custom setups).
- Advanced workflows: Branching, loops, custom code nodes, and error handling.
- Extensible: Build your own connectors or use community-created nodes.
- Free to use if self-hosted.

Weaknesses:

- Requires setup: Self-hosting means you (or your tech team) manage installation and updates.
- User interface: Has improved a lot, but can still feel less polished than Zapier or Make.

- Fewer plug-and-play integrations: Fewer official integrations, though the library is growing fast.
- Support: Limited on the free, self-hosted plan; paid cloud plans get more support.

Pricing (2025):

- Self-hosted: Free (open source).
- Cloud: Starts at ~\$20/month (includes hosting, updates, and basic support).
- Enterprise: Custom plans for large teams.
- N8N Pricing

Support:

- Community support (forums, Discord) for self-hosted users.
- Email and premium support on paid plans.

Review Scores (2025):

- G2: 4.7/5
- Capterra: 4.6/5

Don't forget, you can use it for free if you want to run is locally or on your deployed server.

Summary Table

Platform	Strengths	Weaknesses	Pricing	Support	Review Score
Zapier	Easy, huge app library,	Limited logic, expensive at scale	Free—\$50+/mo	Email, docs, community	G2: 4.5, Capterra: 4.7
Make	Visual, flexible, templates	Learning curve, fewer apps	Free—\$18+/mo	Email, docs, forum	G2: 4.8, Capterra: 4.7
N8N	Open source, self-host, flexible	Setup required, fewer integrations	Free—\$20+/mo	Community, paid	G2: 4.7, Capterra: 4.6

Prompt Example for AI:

"I'm looking to create this type of activity (explain the activity) with workflow automation. Explain which platform would be best to implement this and why."

Section 2: The Power of Automation Workflows

Automating workflows is about making your app and your tools work together, seamlessly. When you connect services with automation, you stop spending time on repetitive tasks and let technology handle routine operations for you. Not only does this save you time, but it also helps you keep your data consistent, respond faster to your users, and build smarter systems that scale easily.

Let's go deeper on how this works in practice, using three detailed, real-world examples with one each for Zapier, Make, and N8N.

Example 1: Automatically Create a Support Ticket from App User Requests

(Using Zapier)

Scenario:

Imagine a user submits a support or bug report from your app (maybe through a contact form or feedback button). You want every submission to instantly create a ticket in your helpdesk tool (like Zendesk, Freshdesk, or Jira), so nothing ever gets lost in your inbox.

How to Build It in Zapier:

Step 1: Set Up the Trigger

- In Zapier, create a new Zap.
- Choose "Webhooks by Zapier" as your trigger app.
- Select the "Catch Hook" event. Zapier will generate a unique webhook URL.
- In your app, configure the support/feedback form to send submissions (via POST) to this Zapier webhook URL.
(So with AI, prompt: "Generate a feedback form that POSTs to this webhook URL: [paste URL here]. Include fields for user email, subject, and message.")

Step 2: Connect to Your Helpdesk Tool

- Add an Action step to your Zap and choose your support platform (Zendesk, Freshdesk, Jira, etc.).
- Select the "Create Ticket" or equivalent action.

Step 3: Map the Form Data

- Map the fields from your webhook (user email, subject, message) to the correct fields in your support tool.

Step 4: Test Your Zap

- Use a test submission from your app to make sure the data flows through and a support ticket appears in your system.

Step 5: Turn On Your Zap

- Once everything works, turn the Zap on.
- Now, every user issue is automatically tracked and assigned so no more digging through emails!

Extra Tips:

- Add a Slack notification or email to your team as a second Action step if you want real-time alerts.

Example 2: Get Notifications in Slack When a Payment is Received

(Using Make.com)

Scenario:

You want your team to get a Slack message every time a user pays through Stripe. That way, you never miss a sale, and your customer service can react right away.

How to Build It in Make:

Step 1: Start a New Scenario

- In Make, click “Create a new scenario.”
- Add a Stripe module as the first step, using the “Watch Events” or “Watch Payments” trigger.
- Connect your Stripe account.

Step 2: Add a Slack Module

- After the payment trigger, add a Slack “Send a Message” module.
- Connect your Slack account and select the desired channel.

Step 3: Map the Data

- Drag and drop fields from Stripe (payer’s name, amount, time, etc.) into your Slack message.

Step 4: Test the Scenario

- Trigger a test payment to ensure the Slack message appears as expected.

Step 5: Schedule and Activate

- Set the scenario to run automatically.
- Now, you get instant Slack updates for every successful payment.

Extra Tips:

- Use filters to only notify for payments over a certain amount, or add more steps to update a database or send a customer email.
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Example 3: Sync Data Between Your App and a Google Sheet for Reporting

(Using N8N)

Scenario:

You want your app's data (like new user signups, bug reports, or feature requests) to be synced to a Google Sheet, so it's easy to analyze or share with team members.

How to Build It in N8N:

Step 1: Create the Trigger

- Start a new workflow in N8N.
- Add a webhook node or another trigger node (like a database poll).

Step 2: Add Google Sheets Node

- Add a Google Sheets "Add Row" node.
- Authenticate your Google account.

Step 3: Map Data

- Map fields from your trigger (user data, timestamp, etc.) to the columns in your Google Sheet.

Step 4: Test and Activate

- Run a test to ensure data lands in your Sheet as expected.
- Activate the workflow.

Extra Tips:

- Add additional logic—like data validation or branching—before sending to Google Sheets.
 - N8N's visual editor lets you see the entire workflow at a glance.
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Why Automation Matters

Each of these examples shows how workflow automation:

- Saves time and reduces errors by taking manual steps out of your process.
 - Improves responsiveness so users and your team always get the right info, instantly.
 - Scales effortlessly as your user base grows—no extra work required.
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Prompt Example for AI

“List five real-world use cases for workflow automation in app development. Focus on onboarding users, sending notifications, and keeping data in sync across tools. For each, explain the steps and recommend which platform to use.”

Section 3: Simple Workflow Example – Beta Signup Flow

Automating your beta signup process is one of the most powerful and practical ways to see workflow automation in action. This example not only reduces your manual workload, but also keeps your early-access users organized and makes it easy to move them through your approval process. Let's walk through how you can set this up using Make.com with just a few building blocks.

Overview: How the Beta Signup Workflow Works

Here's what you'll accomplish:

1. A user signs up for beta access on your site.
Their info (like email and name) gets sent to a webhook endpoint.
2. That info is saved as a new row in a Google Sheet.
This sheet becomes your master list for everyone interested in the beta.
3. When you're ready, you add users to your Supabase whitelist.
This lets you invite users manually and control who gets access.

This workflow keeps everything organized, avoids unnecessary noise for users you're not ready to onboard, and makes it easy to audit and communicate with your beta testers.

Preparation: What You Need to Set Up First

Before you build the automation in Make.com (or Zapier/N8N), it helps to have your tools and accounts ready:

1. Create Your Google Sheet

- Make a new Google Sheet, such as "Beta Signups."
- Add columns you'll want to track—at minimum, something like: Email, Name, Signup Date, Status.
- Leave the sheet empty; the workflow will fill it in as users sign up.

2. Create Your Supabase Whitelist Table

- In your Supabase dashboard, set up a table for beta users so name it something like `beta_whitelist`. (Hint! Ask AI to give you the SQL code to create this)
- Add columns matching your Google Sheet (for easy mapping), such as: `email`, `name`, `invited_at`, `status`.
- This table controls which users are allowed to access your app in beta.

3. Authenticate Your Accounts in Make.com

- In Make.com, connect your Google account (so you can read/write to Sheets).
- Connect your Supabase project by creating a Supabase connection where this will typically ask for your project URL and API key.
- These connections let Make.com talk to your spreadsheet and your database.

4. (Optional but Helpful) Prepare Your Beta Signup Form

- Use Cursor to quickly generate a signup form that will POST data to a webhook URL (you'll get this from Make.com in the next step).
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Building the Workflow: Step by Step in Make.com

Step 1: Create a Webhook in Make.com

- In Make.com, start a new Scenario and add the “Webhooks” module.
- Choose “Custom Webhook” and create a new webhook and Make.com will give you a unique URL.
- This URL is where your beta signup form should POST the user’s data.
- With AI:
Use a prompt like: “Generate a signup form that sends email and name to this webhook URL: [paste your Make.com webhook URL here].”

Step 2: Add Google Sheets to Capture Signups

- After the webhook module, add the “Google Sheets > Add a Row” module.
- Select the Google Sheet you prepared earlier (“Beta Signups”).
- Map each form field (email, name, signup date) from the webhook to the correct columns in your spreadsheet.
- This way, every signup submission instantly becomes a new row in your sheet.

Step 3: Add Supabase to Handle Your Whitelist

- Add the “Supabase > Create a Row” module to your Scenario.
 - Select your beta_whitelist table.
 - Map the relevant fields (email, name, etc.) from the webhook data or Google Sheet row.
 - You can choose to automate this for every signup, or set a filter so only approved users get whitelisted.
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Testing & Verification

1. Connect all the modules in your scenario—Webhook !' Google Sheets !' Supabase.
2. Authenticate all connections:
3. Check your results:

4. (Optional) Take Screenshots:
5. Adjust and Go Live:

Bonus! Have AI create an admin page allowing you to activate or deactivate beta users. Just ask!

Why This Approach Works

- Control: You can keep public signups closed and only onboard users you select from your list.
 - Organization: All your signups are tracked in one place, making it easy to review, sort, or export as needed.
 - Scalability: You can trigger email notifications, invitations, or even user creation in Supabase all from your beta list, and all without manual entry.
 - Auditability: You always know who signed up, who was approved, and when.
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Prompt Example for AI

"Write a detailed step-by-step guide for automating a beta signup process using Make (or Zapier/N8N) that receives web form data, adds it to Google Sheets, and then creates a new row in a Supabase beta whitelist table. Explain each step simply."

Section 4: 100 Workflow Examples to Explore

Introduction

One of the best ways to understand what’s possible with workflow automation is to see it in action. Instead of starting from scratch, you can draw inspiration from real automations that other people (and companies) use every day to make their apps, websites, and businesses run smoother. Below, you’ll find a list of 100 workflow examples. They’re organized by category, so you can quickly find ideas that match your project or interests.

Each example also includes hints about which platform(s) it works best on—Zapier, Make, or N8N—as well as a note about its difficulty (Simple, Intermediate, or Advanced). Use these as starting points, adapt them to your needs, and don’t be afraid to combine several workflows to build something unique!

Tip: Don’t be afraid to modify these examples! For every workflow here, you can swap out the apps or add/remove steps to better fit your situation. Many of the most creative automations come from combining ideas from several categories.

Prompt Examples for AI

“List 20 simple workflow automation ideas for user onboarding using Make.com, Zapier, or N8N. For each, briefly describe what it does, which platform is best, and what apps are connected.”

“Show me 10 advanced automation workflows for data analytics, with at least one using Supabase and Google Sheets.”

100 Workflow Examples to Explore

#	Category	Example Workflow	Platforms	Use Case/Function
1	User Onboarding & Signup Flows	Auto-send welcome emails to new users	Zapier, Make	Customer Engagement
2	User Onboarding & Signup Flows	Add signups from a web form to Google Sheets	Zapier, Make, N8N	Data Collection
3	User Onboarding & Signup Flows	Assign a role to new users in Supabase	Make, N8N	Access Management
4	User Onboarding & Signup Flows	Create a calendar event when a user signs up for a course	Zapier, Make	Scheduling
5	User Onboarding & Signup Flows	Enroll new users into a course platform	Zapier, Make	E-learning
6	User Onboarding & Signup Flows	Send an SMS confirmation after a new signup	Make, N8N	Notifications
7	User Onboarding & Signup Flows	Add a new user to your Slack community after signup	Zapier, Make	Community